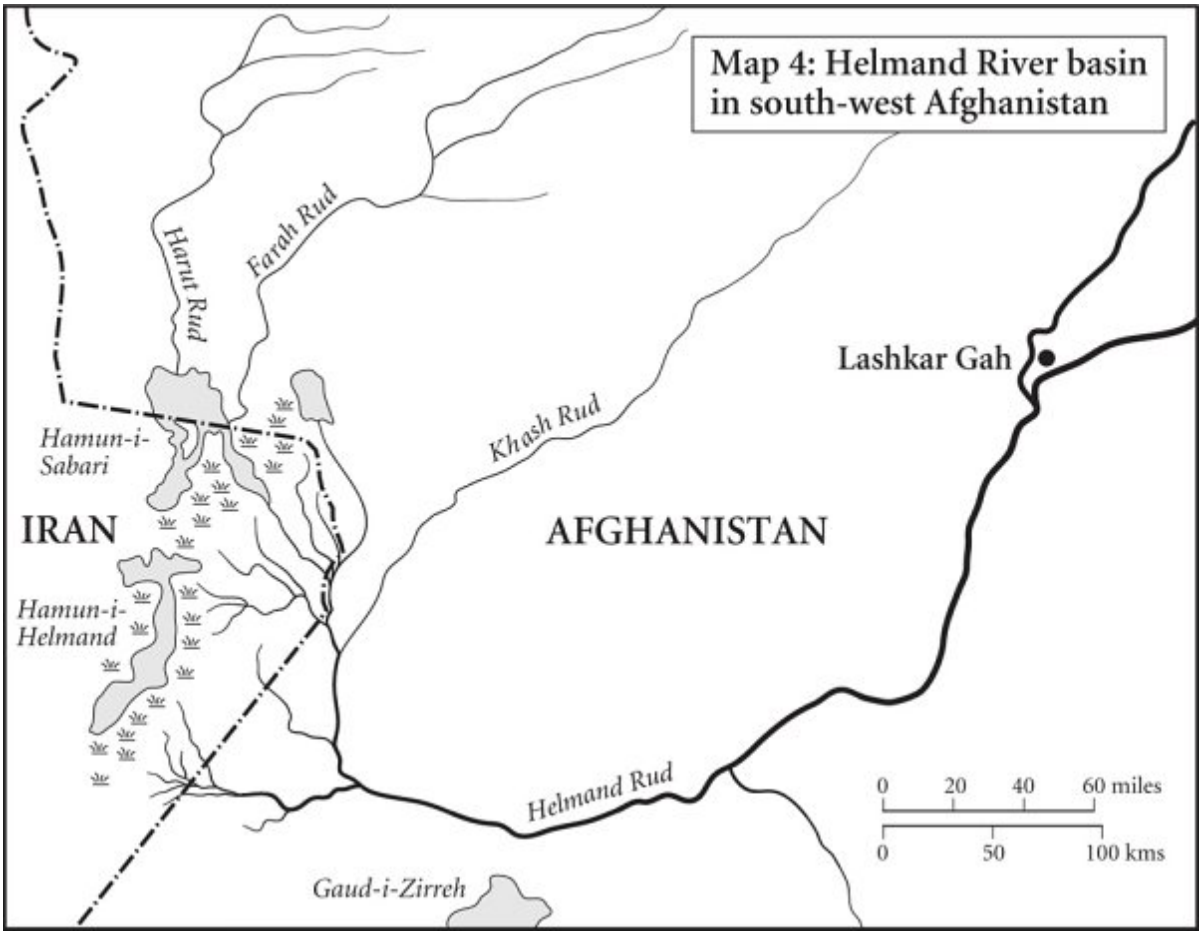
lake also fed by the more impressive Helmand River (referred to in the Avesta as the ‘Haetumant’ – see Map 4). This Harauvati River was sacred to the Zoroastrians as the home of the river goddess Surta Anahitya, the ‘mighty and pure one’, the divinity of the waters who nurtured cattle and crops and was associated with fertility, healing and wisdom. Surta Anahitya is not so much the goddess Saraswati’s twin-sister as herself by another name. Here, then, is the real Saraswati River and the original Arya homeland.



The Helmand River basin in south-west Afghanistan, showing the Harut River (‘Harut Rud’, top left on the map) with its three sources flowing into the marshlands of Hamun-i-Helmand from the north. This was the original Saraswati River and thus the original Arya homeland of Brahmavarta.

Five thousand years ago this first Brahmavarta of the Arya was significantly less hostile than it is today. But the same